CHAPTER IV

The Privilege of Uncertainty

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“How curious that the smallest certainties can bring us the greatest happiness, while a single unanswered question can quietly unsettle them all. We learn to treasure ordinary gestures, to find meaning in words spoken without intention, and sometimes to fear the answers to questions we have not yet dared to ask. Perhaps uncertainty is not always the absence of happiness, but the fragile place in which hope continues to live.”

By the time Utkarsh reached home on the evening of 11 July, he could recall the afternoon with an accuracy he seldom brought to his studies. The scraping chair. Sanondita moving her phone so that he could see. The number beneath his unfinished calculation. He had spent months wondering how to speak to her; now he had spoken, and the memory seemed both perfectly clear and faintly improbable. Sitting with his phone in his hand, he looked at her saved contact for the third time.

Possessing someone’s number and knowing what to do with it were evidently different accomplishments.

He opened WhatsApp and found the empty conversation. A greeting would do. There was no need to approach the matter as though he were drafting a diplomatic communiqué between two countries with a history of strained relations. He typed Hello, considered adding her name, and decided that might sound formal. Without her name, however, it seemed impersonal. After several minutes, he arrived at a compromise.

Hello, it’s me.

He pressed send before he could improve it into something worse.

Only afterward did the problem occur to him. He had never introduced himself. It's me was an exceptionally unhelpful identification from someone whose name he had neglected to provide. He stared at the message. There was something almost admirable about managing to sound both familiar and anonymous in three words.

He could send another message. Explain that he was the classmate from that afternoon. The one with the PDF, perhaps, or the chair, although he hoped neither had become his defining characteristic. But a second introduction would acknowledge the failure of the first, and he was reluctant to establish himself as a man who required two attempts to say hello.

Then her reply appeared.

I saved it.

He read it again. She had saved his number. Whatever confusion he had anticipated, she had answered without requiring him to repair the greeting. His smile came before he could consider whether the reply warranted one.

He thought of asking about her evening, then hesitated. They had only properly spoken that afternoon. He didn't want to turn a pleasant conversation into an unsolicited correspondence about her dinner, sleep schedule, and general well-being before the next morning. There would be classes, examinations, questions about preparation. He could write when he had a reason.

Satisfied with the maturity of this decision, he put the phone aside and returned to his books.

Five minutes later, he checked WhatsApp again. He merely wished to confirm that the application was functioning normally. It was.

The following two days were remarkably ordinary, which he found both reassuring and faintly disappointing. Sanondita arrived at coaching, sat beside Diya, and attended to the lessons with the same

concentration as before. When the occasion arose, she greeted him. He responded with what he hoped was composure, then remembered the exchange for rather longer than a greeting required.

He continued sitting with his friends, though his interest in the arrangement of chairs had become almost scholarly. Diya was generally beside Sanondita. Sometimes he chose a place a little nearer, telling himself that proximity to the board improved concentration. Generations of teachers supported this argument. The direction in which his attention wandered occasionally undermined it.

For now, he liked the small familiarity between them. Sanondita was someone he could speak to. He no longer needed an elaborate excuse, even if he had not entirely lost his talent for inventing one.

On Friday, the fourteenth, he opened WhatsApp that evening and began going through the familiar succession of statuses: birthday wishes, photographs, fragments of other people's afternoons. Then Sanondita's name appeared. He opened hers without hesitation, pleased by the ordinary fact of finding her there.

It was a birthday wish. In the accompanying mirror selfie, she was sitting behind a young man on a motorcycle. She had taken the photograph herself.

Utkarsh looked at the unfamiliar face, waiting to feel as little about it as he had about the other statuses. Instead, he looked longer.

A friend, perhaps. Someone from college. A relative.

Each explanation was possible. He tried to settle on one and found himself returning to the photograph, as though the young man might become identifiable if examined with sufficient care. He knew nothing about him. A birthday greeting was a birthday greeting. People occasionally wished happy birthday even to people they genuinely liked.

Ordinarily, that thought might have amused him.

He closed the status. A little later, he opened it again.

Now he wondered when the picture had been taken, where they had been going, whether Sanondita remembered that day with pleasure. Questions he couldn't answer gathered around a photograph that had offered him no explanation in the first place. He tried to catch himself at it. A mirror selfie was insufficient material from which to reconstruct an entire relationship. His imagination appeared to disagree.

The picture stayed the same. What unsettled him was how easily Sanondita belonged in it. There was a day he knew nothing about, a person he had never seen, a part of her life that had continued before and beyond the classroom in which he noticed her. On Tuesday, learning her subject and hearing her ask about his had felt like getting to know her. He hadn't considered how much remained outside those few answers.

For a moment, he thought of asking Tanisha whether she recognised the man. He dismissed the idea. He could already hear himself explaining that he was conducting a perfectly innocent investigation into the principal male subject of Sanondita's birthday wish. Even in the privacy of his thoughts, the explanation sounded poor.

He could ask Sanondita herself. That possibility made him more uncomfortable. She had given him a number, not agreed to explain the people in her photographs. He knew the difference. He set the phone down.

An Arithmetic problem lay open before him. He read its first line, then read it again. There was an answer somewhere among those figures. He could follow the steps, check the calculation, and arrive at something certain. He held his pen above the page without writing.

His mind went back to the afternoon of the eleventh. Her patience when he fell behind. Their reflection in the lift. The walk to the place where their roads separated. Those things had happened; the photograph could not undo them. Yet remembering

them now brought a question he had managed to leave alone until Friday.

What if there was someone already?

He looked at the untouched calculation. It embarrassed him to discover how much he wanted the answer to be no. He barely knew Sanondita. He had asked for help with the lesson and a way to contact her. Nevertheless, some part of him had begun arranging a future out of afternoons that had not occurred, and an unfamiliar face was enough to disturb the arrangement.

He picked up the phone once more. This time, he opened their conversation.

Hello, it's me.

I saved it.

The words had not changed. They were neither warmer nor colder than on Tuesday. He read them without finding what he was looking for, then locked the screen. Sanondita had wished someone a happy birthday. He was the one who had spent the evening trying to learn something from it that she had never said.

He would not ask her. He would not decide who the man was simply because one answer would let him feel better. Still, as he put the phone away, he hoped the young man was only a friend. Knowing that the question wasn't his to demand did little to make him stop wishing for an answer.

By Monday, Utkarsh had almost convinced himself that the photograph no longer mattered. Almost remained an important qualification. He had stopped opening the status, an achievement assisted by its having expired after twenty-four hours. He preferred to regard it as evidence of personal growth.

Seeing Sanondita at coaching brought relief he hadn't expected. She sat beside Diya, occasionally exchanging a few words with her, then returned to the lesson. She was as familiar as she had been before the weekend. For a while, he could follow the teacher without thinking of the photograph. Then she would turn a page or

speak, and he would remember that there were people who knew her in ways he did not.

After coaching, she went home. Utkarsh accompanied Deepesh, Tanisha, and Nikita to the library. Other students were already there, and the four found places together on a bench. Their conversation moved from one subject to another, occasionally interrupted by someone nearby looking up in disapproval.

Utkarsh joined in. Between remarks, however, he kept glancing towards Tanisha. She knew Sanondita better than he did. Perhaps she had seen the status. Perhaps she knew who the man was. He let one pause pass, then another. Asking would reveal how much attention he had given the picture. Remaining quiet was proving less dignified than he had hoped, considering how much effort it required.

"Tanisha," he said eventually, keeping his voice casual, "you saw Sanondita's status on Friday, right?"

She looked up. "Which one?"

"The birthday wish."

"I don't remember."

"The one with the guy on the motorcycle."

He had added that a little too quickly.

"Oh, yes. That one."

He nodded as though her recollection had been the entire purpose of the inquiry. A moment passed.

"Do you know him?"

"No." She looked at him more carefully. "Why?"

"Nothing. I was just wondering."

Tanisha considered him for another second.

"Probably a friend."

"Yeah. Probably."

She smiled faintly. "You've been thinking about it?"

"Not particularly."

“Then how did you remember it?”

“Some things stay in your memory.”

“Like birthdays?”

“Like evidence that I should mind my own business.”

That earned a small smile. He was grateful she didn’t press further. Deepesh was saying something to Nikita, and the conversation moved on. Utkarsh joined them, lighter despite having learned almost nothing.

Probably a friend. Tanisha hadn’t recognised him. Her suggestion was no more reliable than his own, but hearing it from her made it easier to hold. He wondered whether she had offered it to reassure him, then stopped trying to work that out as well. One unanswered question had already consumed enough of the weekend.

For the rest of the afternoon, the photograph troubled him less. He could remember Tuesday without immediately placing an unfamiliar man beside it. Sanondita had helped him, spoken to him, and given him her number. None of those things promised anything more. They were still his to remember.

July was approaching its end, and with it came the SSC CGL Tier-I examination for which Utkarsh and his friends had supposedly been preparing. They had begun only a few months earlier. None of them believed that a handful of months would compensate for everything they had yet to learn. Utkarsh intended to appear, do what he could, and come away knowing how much work remained. It was a modest expectation, sturdy enough to survive almost any result.

Their WhatsApp conversation had remained almost untouched since the eleventh. He sometimes opened it with a question in mind, only to discover that he could obtain the answer without troubling her. Being reasonably well-informed was becoming an unfortunate obstacle to communication.

The approaching examination offered a subject that might withstand scrutiny. Documents to carry, instructions to follow, the usual precautions by which a candidate could avoid being defeated

at the centre by an absent photograph or an incorrect identity card. He already knew what he needed.

This was inconvenient, but not insurmountable.

He typed a question about the required documents, read it again, and sent it. It sounded ordinary and practical. Nobody looking at it would know how long he had spent looking for something to ask. When Sanondita replied, she told him what to carry. He thanked her. The exchange ended almost as soon as it had begun.

He looked at the screen. So much deliberation, and the resulting conversation could be completed in less time than it took to reconsider sending it. Still, he was glad. For a few moments, he had been able to speak to her without a classroom full of witnesses. He left the reply where it was and returned to his preparation.

The examinations arrived. Utkarsh attended his, confronted the questions with varying degrees of confidence, and emerged suspecting that the people who set competitive examinations possessed a rather bleak understanding of human happiness. Some questions had been manageable. Others had seemed personally offended by his presence. He did not dwell on it for long. This was their first attempt, and he had gone in without extravagant expectations. There would be other examinations, and considerably more preparation before them.

He remembered when Sanondita was due to appear. The following day, he opened their conversation again. This time, he did not need to invent a reason. He wanted to know how it had gone.

How was your exam?

They exchanged a few words about the paper. He lingered over the conversation, pleased by being able to ask about her day even when the day involved an examination neither of them was likely to remember fondly. Then he considered another question.

Will you come tomorrow?

He hesitated before sending it. Asking about an examination was straightforward. Asking whether she would be there tomorrow admitted, however slightly, that her presence mattered to him. He

wondered whether she would notice. He wondered whether he wanted her to.

Eventually, he sent it.

Yes.

He smiled. She would be there. He was considering how to end the conversation when another message appeared.

You coming?

For a few seconds, he looked at the screen without replying.

She had asked about his studies in the classroom. But their WhatsApp exchanges had generally begun and ended with his questions and her answers. Now she had asked whether he would be there too. He had spent so long deciding how much of his wish to see her could safely appear in a sentence that the ease of hers caught him unprepared.

Yes, he replied.

He considered adding something, then left it alone. There was no need to improve a perfectly good moment into a less satisfactory one. He put the phone aside.

A few minutes later, he picked it up and reread the exchange. He could imagine her typing the question casually, without the slightest difficulty, perhaps while doing something else. It was ordinary courtesy between classmates. He knew that, and remained happy enough to read it once more.

The man in the photograph was still a stranger. Tanisha's reassurance had not changed that. But tomorrow Sanondita would be at coaching, and she had asked whether he would be there. He could look forward to those two things without solving the rest of her life first.

In the days that followed, Diya became less regular at coaching. Sometimes she missed a day. Sometimes she attended the first class and left before the second. Utkarsh developed an embarrassingly precise awareness of these arrangements. There were students whose attendance interested him far less, including, on occasion,

his own. Yet he could scarcely enter the classroom without noticing whether the chair beside Sanondita was occupied.

The first few times it was empty, he stayed with his friends. Nobody had assigned seats. He had already spent an afternoon beside her; he could walk over and ask. But on the eleventh he had possessed a question, an excuse, and a chair willing to announce his intentions to the room. Now he would simply be choosing to sit beside her. The simpler truth was harder to disguise.

He found practical objections. Diya might return. Sanondita might prefer the place kept free. Asking permission might seem unnecessarily formal. Not asking might seem presumptuous. He could contemplate an unsuccessful government examination with reasonable composure, but an unoccupied chair required a private inquiry into its social consequences.

Deepesh noticed one afternoon after Diya had left. Utkarsh was sitting a little behind Sanondita while they waited for the teacher. Deepesh followed his gaze with an efficiency that would have been useful had he applied it to his own problems.

“Go and sit there,” he said quietly.

“Where?”

Deepesh looked at him.

Utkarsh sighed. “What?”

“Nothing. I was wondering how long you intend to study that chair.”

“I’m not studying it.”

“Good. Because I don’t think it’s coming in the examination.”

Utkarsh gave him a reluctant smile. “You have a very unhealthy interest in where I sit.”

“And you have a very healthy interest in where you don’t.”

Utkarsh opened his notebook. There was little to gain by continuing when Deepesh had the advantage of being correct. From near the front, Sanondita said something to another student. He recognised her voice immediately. Deepesh glanced at him but, for

once, offered no commentary. There were limits to how much accurate observation a friendship ought to permit.

What made it difficult was how much Utkarsh remembered of that first afternoon. The uncomfortable beginning, certainly, but also the ease that had come later: asking which question they were on, comparing answers, speaking without deciding on every word in advance. He wanted that again. For Sanondita, his taking a seat might mean nothing beyond another classmate taking a seat. He wanted to be able to manage that difference without making it her problem.

Over the following days, the chair appeared often enough to lose its novelty. Sometimes Diya returned before he decided to move. Sometimes she didn’t, and he remained where he was anyway. The disappointment was peculiar. He had not been refused anything. He could leave class feeling that an opportunity had passed, and still know he had been the one to let it pass.

One afternoon, he arrived to find Diya absent. Sanondita was already there, looking through her notebook as the room filled around her. Utkarsh stood near his usual place, his bag in his hand. There was no reason this day should be different. He had no new question to ask, no particular excuse to offer.

For a moment, he remembered the photograph. He still knew nothing more about it. Then Sanondita turned a page, and he looked at the chair beside her. He could remain here until he knew enough about her life to feel safe from disappointment. He would probably become a permanent feature of the classroom before that happened.

He took a step towards the front. Another student passed between the rows, and he stopped to let them through. As he adjusted his bag strap, he smiled involuntarily. He was crossing a classroom, not embarking on a journey for which he ought to have informed his family and arranged suitable provisions.

He could ask whether the chair was free. If she wanted to keep it for Diya, he could return to his place. The world would continue

under either arrangement. He waited for the student to pass, then went on before he could assemble another respectable reason not to.

Sanondita looked up when he reached her row. For an inconvenient second, he forgot the words. He knew the question required only two; his ability to produce either seemed less certain. He adjusted the strap of his bag, glanced at the chair to her right, and smiled.

“May I?”

She looked at the seat.

“Yeah, sure.”

She moved her things a little to make room. He thanked her and sat down, putting his bag where it wouldn’t obstruct her. For days, he had approached the prospect with the seriousness of an irreversible decision. She had settled it in less time than it took him to fit his legs beneath the writing tablet.

He opened his notebook. Sanondita returned to hers. He could hear the soft movement of a page when she turned it, and it brought back the phone resting between them on the eleventh. That afternoon had seemed an exception. Now he had asked without a borrowed screen or a conveniently forgotten phone, and she had made room.

Their attached writing surfaces left little space for careless movement. He settled slightly towards the outer edge of his chair and kept his arm within his own desk. The final few inches were apparently protected by an international treaty. Still, he could turn towards her without having to raise his voice across a row. He looked at the open page and allowed himself to be pleased.

The teacher hadn’t arrived. Behind them, a student was telling a story that grew less believable with each sentence. Others looked at their phones or continued conversations they would later pretend to resent having to interrupt.

Sanondita glanced towards the doorway.

“Sir’s late today.”

“Maybe he’s giving us time to revise,” Utkarsh said.

“If only we used it.”

There was a little amusement in her voice. He smiled. He hadn’t rehearsed his answer, and she hadn’t needed him to ask a question before speaking. For a few seconds, he had forgotten to wonder whether he belonged in the chair.

A student passing between the rows brushed its back. Utkarsh shifted instinctively, then checked that he hadn’t moved too close. Sanondita continued with her notebook. He settled again. She could turn a page, reach for her pen, or move her things without having to consider him. He liked that she seemed able to do so as easily as before he had arrived.

When the teacher came in, conversations subsided. Utkarsh turned towards the board and began writing. Occasionally, the simple awareness of Sanondita beside him made him lose a few words of the explanation. He caught up. His choice of chair was not supposed to affect his chances in the next examination.

Once, she leaned towards her notebook. He adjusted his position slightly, then returned to the lesson. The movement passed unnoticed. For all the time he had spent wishing to be closer, it was enough to be close enough to speak. He didn’t need to narrow the gap each time she moved.

He still wondered what she thought of him. Somewhere beneath his composure, he hoped she might remember this afternoon too, might one day regard him as someone whose company made an ordinary class a little more pleasant. It was difficult to admit how much he wanted that. It was more difficult to accept that she might go home without thinking about where he had sat at all.

He glanced at the board. A student answered a question incorrectly; a few others exchanged the brief, knowing looks that accompanied such occasions. Sanondita turned a page. Utkarsh moved his notebook to give himself more room, taking care not to disturb hers.

The man in the photograph remained unidentified. Yet Utkarsh knew he would remember the ease of Sanondita's reply. He had not waited for certainty before walking over. He had not needed an excuse.

Beside him, she continued writing. Utkarsh followed the teacher's next line, their arms still comfortably apart. For now, he could sit there without needing the afternoon to tell him what would happen afterward.